The Dawes Act

Before 1887, Native American tribes held and cared for their lands communally: no single person “owned” a plot; the entire tribe shared it. The U.S. government passed the Dawes General Allotment Act to end this system.

The government surveyed reservations and split the shared land into small, individual private plots given to Native families. Any leftover territory was labeled “surplus” and sold off to non-Native settlers, railroads, and corporations.

Under the guise of “civilizing” tribes through private ownership, this legal sleight of hand stripped Native Americans of roughly 90 million acres, two-thirds of their entire land base. The following exhibits trace how simple administrative labels transformed sacred communal homelands into commercial real estate, and how indigenous leaders fought to preserve their treaties.